

place of unbridled passion that existed in the Western imagination. In reality, only a handful of sultans slept with multiple women, and European visitors observed that the harem shared similarities with a nunnery due to its strict hierarchy.

Power in the harem

Some women in the imperial harem became powerful political figures within the Ottoman court. This was most evident during the period known as the “Sultanate of Women,” from around 1520 to the mid 17th century. Solomon Schweigger, a Catholic priest



◀ Turkish luxury

In this photograph from the end of the 19th century, a woman smokes a *nargile* (water pipe)—a pastime that emerged in Turkey in the 17th century as a status symbol among the elites.

30 of the Ottoman sultans were the sons of women from the harem

and translator of the Qur'an who traveled through Turkey in the 16th century, commented that “The Turks govern the world and their wives govern them.” The sultan’s favorite consort—the Haseki Sultan—was influential. The earliest recipient of this

title was Hürrem (see right), who married Suleiman I the Magnificent—the first time a sultan took a concubine as his wife. Even more powerful was the mother of the reigning sultan. Known as the Valide Sultan, she was a custodian of power whose role was to guide her son, and act as regent for an underage sultan. One of these was Kösem Sultan, a slave concubine of Greek origin, who served as regent for her son

Murad IV from 1623–1632 and from 1648–1651 for her grandson Mehmed IV.

Outside of the harem, women in Ottoman society also enjoyed independence and agency. Women were part of the waged labor force, often in the manufacture of textiles and clothing. Wealthy women could set up as money lenders or become silent business partners with a male merchant. Although legal, polygamy was rare in the Ottoman Empire by the 16th and 17th centuries.

Divorce was common; a husband could divorce his wife without explanation, although he had to provide her with financial compensation. A wife could “purchase” a divorce by renouncing her claim to compensation. Although

Ottoman men still had authority over women, the latter had some rights (such as divorce) before women in other parts of Europe and Asia.



BIOGRAPHY

HÜRREM SULTAN

Born Aleksandra Lisovska in Ruthenia (modern Ukraine), in around 1520, Hürrem was kidnapped by Tatars and sold into the harem of Suleiman I. She converted to Islam and took the name Hürrem, but was also known as Roxelana. Hürrem became Suleiman’s favorite concubine, and bore him five sons. In c. 1533 they married, freeing Hürrem from slavery. Hürrem advised her husband and played an active role in state affairs. Her unprecedented rise led to rumors of witchcraft, but she remained influential at court until her death in 1558.